

FREE SAMPLE

Hamster Care Package

The first 5 pages of the 47-page printable manual, free to keep.



In this sample: What's inside, How to Use This Package, Quick Profile & Cost Overview, The Species, Size & Lifespan. The contents page shows every one of the 47 pages, so you can see exactly what the full package covers before you buy it.

Not in this sample: the 42 pages that follow, which are the full care guide, the health section, the quick reference cards, and the owner tools, checklists and logs.

The full package is \$8.99 at beastlyfacts.com/care-packages/hamster/. One purchase, and every corrected edition is a free re-download from your library. The free hamster care guide it was built from is at beastlyfacts.com/guides/hamster/, and stays free.

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What's inside

Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

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START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

UNITS USED THROUGHOUT

Every temperature and size is given twice: degrees Fahrenheit (°F) with degrees Celsius (°C), and inches (in) and square inches (sq in) with centimeters (cm) and square centimeters (cm²), and bar gaps in millimeters (mm). A hamster is weighed in grams (g), with ounces (oz) beside it, and its water is measured in milliliters (ml). Humidity is a percentage (%) of the moisture the air could hold. Prices are in United States dollars.

If you haven't set up yet

Check the law first, on page 23: a hamster is legal in nearly every state, but two are exceptions. Then read the housing pages, starting at page 6, in order before buying anything. The enclosure and the bedding are expensive to redo, and the pet-shop starter kit gets both wrong: too small for the floor space and too shallow for the bedding. Buy the enclosure once, using the Budget & Shopping List on page 33, and buy it bigger than the kit.

If your hamster is already home

Audit what you have against the Setup Checklist below, starting with bedding depth, the highest-value change available. If your hamster chews the bars, that is a readout of the housing, not a personality trait. And if its rear end is wet or matted, stop reading and go to page 25: a same-day emergency.

Print these first

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ Page 31: Setup Checklist & Targets | ☐ Page 39: Pet-Sitter Sheet |
| ☐ Page 32: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 40: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 36: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 41: Equipment & Vet Log |
| ☐ Page 37: Daily, Weekly & Seasonal Routine | ☐ Page 42: Enrichment Checklist & Log |

WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

Starter-kit cages fall well short of current welfare recommendations. This package reflects current guidance, cross-checked against the sources on page 45.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

A veterinarian who sees small mammals. This is a husbandry reference for day-to-day care. Anything urgent is a vet call, not a page in this book, and in a hamster the same day matters. Find a vet who sees hamsters before you need one. Nothing on the law page is legal advice either.

SECTION 01 · PROFILE

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail.

Scientific name	<i>Mesocricetus auratus</i> for the Syrian or golden hamster; the dwarfs are mostly <i>Phodopus</i>
Adult size	Syrian 5 to 7 in (13 to 18 cm) and 3 to 5 oz (85 to 140 g). Every dwarf stays under 100 g
Lifespan	Syrians 2 to 3 years, Winter Whites often about 1. Median age at death in a large study: 1.75 years
Native range	Northern Syria and southern Turkey: arid steppe and farmland, in extensive burrows
Diet type	Omnivore. A complete pellet or lab block as the staple, small amounts of fresh food, and protein treats (page 11)
Floor space minimum	700 to 775 sq in (4,500 to 5,000 cm ²) unbroken for a Syrian, around 600 sq in (3,900 cm ²) for a dwarf
The one hard rule	Bedding deep enough to burrow in: 6 in (15 cm) is the floor, and the research used 40 cm (page 7)
Temperature	65 to 75°F (18 to 24°C), held steady. No heat lamp and no UVB (ultraviolet B light)
Housing	One per enclosure for a Syrian or Chinese hamster; some dwarfs can share (page 19)
Active hours	Mainly nocturnal. Waking one by day is the commonest way owners get bitten (page 16)
Legal status	Legal in 48 states, the District of Columbia and New York City. Hawaii bans it, and Oregon's rule is unclear
Conservation status	Endangered on the IUCN (International Union for Conservation of Nature) global threatened-species list, for the wild Syrian population

Cost overview

The animal and the setup

About \$25 for a Syrian, \$15 to \$25 for a dwarf. \$165 to \$550 to set up, animal included, with every item priced: \$185 to \$550 with a Syrian, \$165 to \$430 with a dwarf. Every line is on page 33.

Monthly ongoing

\$10 to \$25 for food, vegetables, bedding, chews, bath sand and hay, or \$140 to \$265 a year. Most of it is bedding.

BUDGET FOR THE VET TOO

A small-mammal wellness exam runs about \$80 to \$115, and an emergency exam about \$200 before any tests or treatment. Wet tail is the one to plan for.

Fun facts worth knowing

- Nearly every pet Syrian descends from one litter: the species was brought into captivity from a single wild-caught female found near Aleppo, Syria, in 1930.
- Cheek pouches stretch back as far as the shoulders and can hold roughly a fifth of the hamster's own body weight, which is why a day without seeing it eat may be nothing.

The species, size & lifespan

What you are buying, how big it gets, and how long it stays.

Five pet species

Five species are kept as pets: the Syrian (the largest and the most common), the Winter White, the Campbell's, the Chinese and the Roborovski. The Winter White, Campbell's and Roborovski are the "dwarfs" of the pet trade, and the Chinese hamster is sold alongside them though it does not share their tolerance for company. Temperament varies more by species than most people expect: a Syrian and a Roborovski, both sold under the same label, are genuinely different pets to hold. Where the species differ, the page says which one it means.

In the wild a Syrian is a solitary burrower that digs extensive tunnel systems and is fiercely territorial toward other hamsters, a trait that carries into captivity and is why a Syrian lives alone as an adult.

Size

SPECIES	ADULT LENGTH	WEIGHT
Syrian (golden)	5 to 7 in (13 to 18 cm)	3 to 5 oz (85 to 140 g), females heavier than males
Chinese	4 to 5 in (10 to 13 cm)	Under 100 g
Winter White and Campbell's	2 to 4 in (5 to 10 cm)	Under 100 g
Roborovski	1.5 to 2 in (4 to 5 cm)	Under 100 g

Varieties

Color and coat vary: short-haired, long-haired, satin and curly "rex". They rarely change the price, and this is not a species with morph-driven pricing. The one care difference is the coat: some long-haired hamsters need weekly brushing to take out mats, bedding and debris.

Lifespan

Syrian and Roborovski	2 to 3 years
Chinese	1.5 to 3 years
Winter White	Often only about 12 months
Median across all pet hamsters	1.75 years at death, in a large veterinary study of hamsters under veterinary care, with the range reaching about 3.65 years
Elderly from	1.5 years. From about 2.5 years expect overgrown nails, hair loss, more sleeping and drinking, and slower movement (page 15)

A SHORT COMMITMENT, AND A SHORT MARGIN

That is brief next to almost any other pet. It cuts both ways: less time to spread the setup cost across, but less total expense, and a much smaller commitment to take on. It also leaves little room for wait-and-see with a health problem, which is why the health section is built around same-day action.